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Joshua Nations

Esther

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Esther

Overview and Summary. The books of Ezra and Nehemiah tell of the return of some of the exiled Jews to Jerusalem. But most remained in what had become the kingdom of Persia after the fall of Babylon. The story of Esther takes place during what is believed to be the reign of King Ahasuerus, or Xerxes I, in about 480 BC. The author is not known, but some believe that it could have been written by Mordecai, one of the principal characters in the narrative. The book of Esther, as well as Song of Songs, is unique in that the name of God is not mentioned. But the book shows how God works through events and individuals to accomplish His purposes. It is an amazing story which has been made into several movies. In short, it is a dramatic narrative of God's deliverance of his people through an orphaned Jewish girl who becomes Queen of Persia.

A. Chapter One.

1. We are introduced to King Ahasuerus who is giving a great feast lasting 180 days for his officials. Wine was lavished without restriction. After 180 days, the King gives a feast for seven days for all the people in Susa, the capital of Persia. As a side note, Ahasuerus is believed to be Xerxes I whose army was opposed by the Greeks at the battle of Thermopylae in 480 BC. King Leonidas of Sparta, with 300 of his personal bodyguards and other Greek forces, held the narrow pass of Thermopylae against a massive Persian army for three days, ultimately dying to the last man. The invasion was ultimately stopped the next year, ending the second of two invasion attempts by the Persians. The first was by Xerxes's father Darius I, who was defeated by the Greek state of Athens at the battle of Marathon in 490 BC. That battle has given its title to the Marathon race of 26 miles, honoring the Greek soldier who ran to Athens and reported victory, dying in the process. It could be that the feasts given by Ahasuerus were a means for him to compensate for these losses.
2. Queen Vashti also gives a feast for the women in the palace. At the end of the seven days, Ahasuerus, who is "merry with wine", calls for Queen Vashti to appear wearing her crown to "show the people and princes her beauty for she was lovely to look at" (Vs. 1:11). Vashti refuses which enraged Ahasuerus. Scripture is silent as to the reason why Vashti refused. Rabbinical tradition is that it was expected that she would appear wearing nothing but her crown which

would explain her refusal. But this is just speculation. The King asks his advisors what should be done to Queen Vashti. They tell him that not only did Queen Vashti do wrong to the King but that all women will now “look at their husbands with contempt” (Vs. 1:17). They tell him that Vashti must never appear before the King again and her place given to another.

B. Chapter Two.

1. The young men who advised the King, tell him “Let beautiful young virgins be sought out for the King” (Vs. 2:2). This pleases the King, and officers in the various provinces were instructed to seek out beautiful maidens and have them be sent to Susa. Here we are introduced to Esther, called Hadassah, and her older first cousin Mordecai, who adopted Esther after her parents died. She and other young women were placed under the care of Hegai, who was in charge of the King’s harem. She and seven other maidens were advanced to the best place in the harem. Mordecai had instructed her not to make known that she was Jewish. He walked every day in front of the court of the harem to learn how she was.
2. The maidens were prepared for a year with various spices and ointments. Then they would each go in to the King in the evening and then to another harem in the morning. They would not go into the King again unless called for. When Esther went into the King, she won his favor, and he made her Queen and set the crown upon her head.
3. Two of the King’s eunuchs who guarded the gate became angry at the King and plotted to kill him. Mordecai heard of the plot and told Esther who in turn told the King. The two were hanged and a record was made.

C. Chapter Three.

1. We are introduced to another major character in this story of Esther. Haman, who we are told is an Agagite, is promoted by the King over all of the officials. Haman was most likely a descendent of Agag, King of the Amalekites, who we remember from 1 Samuel 15:3. The Amalekites were long time enemies of the Jewish people, and King Saul was instructed to destroy them. Due to his disobedience, he lost his kingship and now, centuries later, Haman will initiate a plot to annihilate the Jews.
2. Haman was a close confidant of the King who instructed the officials that they were to bow down to him in homage. Mordecai did not and his Jewish heritage

was made known. When Haman learns of Mordecai's refusal, he plots to not only destroy Mordecai, but all Jews within Persia. Haman deceived the King by telling him that the Jews have their own laws and do not keep those of the King. The King is persuaded to issue an edict to kill all the Jews in Persia. A day is selected by casting lots, called a "pur" in Persian.

D. Chapter Four.

1. Esther finds out about the edict from Mordecai. She tells him via a eunuch that was assigned to her that anyone who approaches the king without permission could be put to death unless he extends a golden scepter to that person. When Mordecai learns what Esther has said, he instructs the messenger to tell her: "Do not think to yourself that in the king's palace you will escape any more than all the other Jews. For if you keep silent at this time, relief and deliverance will rise for the Jews from another place, but you and your father's house will perish. And who knows whether you have not come to the kingdom for such a time as this?" (Vs. 4:13-14).
2. Esther agrees and instructs him to gather all the Jews in Susa to fast for three days, and that she and her maiden will do the same. She then says: "Then I will go to the king, though it is against the law, and if I perish, I perish" (Vs. 4:16b).

E. Chapter Five.

1. After three days, Esther puts on her royal robes and goes to the King's court. The King extends his scepter and Esther touches the tip of it. The King asks what is her request, and that he would grant it up to half of his kingdom. She asks that he and Haman come to a feast that she has prepared. They come, and again the king asks what is her request. She again asks both of them to come to another feast the next day at which she will reveal her request. Scripture is silent as to why Esther delayed her request until a second feast was held. Bible commentators give various speculative reasons, but as we see the story unfold, we see God's sovereign timing and the complete humiliation of the prideful Haman.
2. At the second feast invitation, Haman is elated. As he goes out, he is angered to see that Mordecai does not tremble or bow down to him. He goes home and relates all that has transpired. His wife tells him to build a gallows 50 cubits high, and tell the king to have Mordecai hanged upon it. This pleases Haman and he has it built.

F. Chapter Six.

1. That same night, the King cannot sleep, and he calls for the official records to be brought to him. He hears of Mordecai's preventing the two eunuchs from harming him. He asks what honor had been bestowed upon Mordecai. When he learns that nothing had been done, he asks who is in the court at that moment. Haman had just entered to request that Mordecai be hanged. The King asks him what should be done to someone who the King wishes to honor. Haman, thinking that it is him, tells him that he should be dressed in the King's robes, placed upon the King's horse, and paraded through the square by an official while crying out that this is the way the King delights to honor.
2. The King tells him to quickly carry out this task to Mordecai. Afterwards, Mordecai returns to the gate but Haman hurries to his house mourning. Haman's wife and friends tell him "If Mordecai, before whom you have begun to fall, is of the Jewish people, you will not overcome him but will surely fall before him" (Vs. 6:13b). While they are talking, eunuchs arrive to take Haman to the second feast that Esther has arranged.

G. Chapter Seven.

1. On the second day, the King asks Esther what is her request. She asks for her life and that of her people and exposes Haman's evil plot. The king arises from the wine drinking in a rage and goes into the garden. Haman falls upon the couch where Esther is and begs her for mercy.
2. The King comes in at that moment and cries out "Will he even assault the queen in my presence, in my own house?" (Vs. 7:8b). As these words come out of the mouth of the King, they cover Haman's face signifying his death. One of the eunuchs who was serving the king, tells him of the gallows at Haman's house that Haman had prepared to hang Mordecai. The King tells them to take Haman there and hang him upon it. They do so, and the King's wrath is abated.

H. Chapter Eight. As the previous edict of the King could not be revoked, Ahasuerus has Mordecai issue a new edict sent by couriers to all 127 provinces which would allow the Jews to defend themselves against any that would seek to harm them. "And in every province and in every city, wherever the king's command and his edict reached, there was gladness and joy among the Jews, a feast and a holiday. And many from the peoples of the country declared themselves Jews, for fear of the Jews had fallen on them" (Vs. 8:17).

I. Chapter Nine. The Jews kill their enemies for two days but do not take plunder. The ten sons of Haman are hanged on gallows. The celebration of Purim is initiated, which is named after the casting of lots for the day that was originally intended to kill all the Jews.

J. Chapter Ten. Mordecai advances to the rank of second in command of Persia after King Ahasuerus. "He was great among the Jews and popular with the multitude of his brothers, for he sought the welfare of his people and spoke peace to all his people" (Vs. 10:3b).

K. Discussion Questions, Application and Passing it On.

1. As was mentioned in the opening summary to this book, the name of God is not mentioned even once. Nor is there mention that when the Jews fasted that they also prayed. But, where do you see God's sovereign hand at work in events and individuals in this narrative?
2. Haman was an Agagite, most probably the descendant of King Agag of the Amalekites, long-time enemies of the Jews. If King Saul had followed God's instructions to kill all of the Amalekites, Haman and his evil plot would never have happened. Bible critics have termed God's instruction a genocide and used it, and other passages where God instructs the Jews to kill the Canaanites and other tribes, such as in Deuteronomy 20:16-17, to attack the concept of a loving God. Many believers have fallen away from the faith due to such criticism. From what you have learned from reading previous summaries of Bible books, what was the purpose of God in doing this? Are you now equipped to give an explanation to someone who may be doubting the Bible and God's divine attributes?
3. Esther was sovereignly placed as Queen of Persia "for such a time as this". Do you believe that you also have been placed where you are to accomplish God's purpose at such a time as this?

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